

THE STORY SO FAR

- 1 **RAMESH CHAUHAN SOLD HIS SOFT DRINKS BUSINESS CONSISTING OF BRANDS LIKE THUMS UP, MAAZA AND LIMCA TO COCA-COLA IN 1993 FOR \$60 MILLION**
- 2 **A FEW YEARS LATER, HE TURNED HIS ATTENTION TO BISLERI TO BUILD A MARKET AROUND PACKAGED DRINKING WATER**
- 3 **SUSTAINED INVESTMENTS MADE IN MANUFACTURING AND BRAND BUILDING HELPED MAKE BISLERI THE TOP PLAYER**
- 4 **THE COMPANY NOW WANTS A BIGGER PRESENCE IN SOFT DRINKS AND ALSO DOMINATE THE HIGHLY-FRAGMENTED WATER BUSINESS**
- 5 **A DEAL TO SELL OUT TO TATA CONSUMER PRODUCTS FELL THROUGH AND CHAUHAN'S DAUGHTER JAYANTI IS CLEAR THAT SHE WANTS TO GROW THE BUSINESS**



PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR

“WE WANT TO CREATE THE MOST UNIQUE PRODUCT PORTFOLIO AND ARE VERY SERIOUS ABOUT THE BUSINESS... [WE] ARE NOT EVEN THINKING OF A SALE”

JAYANTI CHAUHAN
VICE CHAIRPERSON, BISLERI INTERNATIONAL

In the case of the 20-litre container, reusing is relatively easy. Apart from being environmentally-conscious, it leads to greater and more efficient cost control at the level of the business. “Bisleri imported a plastic recycling machine in the early 1990s. We have a good understanding of the whole model today,” says Angelo.

Being the first player in the business allowed Bisleri to set up the ecosystem from scratch. “In terms of innovation, we were the ones who brought the tamper-proof bottles into the market or the PET version with a focus on affordability. The 5-litre and 20-litre versions were also from our stable,” says Chauhan.

Of course, the company has one huge advantage—

brand Bisleri’s generic nature to the category. “Xerox is the best example and something similar has taken place with Bisleri, since it is the first packaged water brand in India,” feels Jaiswal. In fact, many consumers ask for Bisleri when they mean mineral water.

Jaiswal recalls a phase around 1999-2000, when Kinley and Aquafina—packaged water brands owned by Coca-Cola and PepsiCo, respectively—decided to put in big money. But, “Bisleri was smart in investing both in manufacturing and marketing.” A case in point was the 1.2-litre offering or for that matter the 5- and 20-litre cans, where the multinationals have a very small presence. In the organised market in these